

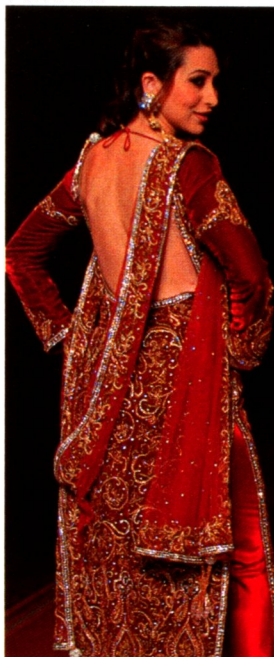


FLOWER FANCIES

Fabric embellishments like organza flowers on saris and salwar kameezes are the season's must-haves. Creations by Pallavi Jaikishen (top) and Tahiliani.



MANJARI DEOGHAR



SKIN IS IN

Be it a low slung ghaghra or a choli held together just by strings. (L to R) Karisma Kapur in a Gangwani, Priyanka Chopra in Ritu Kumar and Shilpa Shetty in a Tahiliani.



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trousseau trunk airing. "Couture in India is still a very niche market and constitutes mostly the bride or at the most someone who wants to buy a custom-made outfit," says Tahiliani.

Which is why each year, it attracts new converts. Like Varun Bahl, known for his avant garde prêt, who started a wedding line last year. After his first full blown showing in Mumbai, he's returned to Delhi with multiple stores looking at stocking his Mughal-meets-Elizabethan era collection of velvet capes over embellished skirts.

Without being risqué, brides are also daring to bare with either a bit more cleavage or a wee bit more of their washboard abs. But towering over these two is the bare back. It was visible on Couture Week's ramp when Priyanka Chopra walked out in a Kumar ghaghra with a choli barely held together by a string and also when Karisma Kapoor paused to show a bare back in an otherwise plain looking red and gold churidar kurta with full sleeves. Malhotra also flirted with short cholis and bare backs. And this trend has walked straight into stores, where it's being eagerly lapped up.

Not only are the designers benefiting, but the traditional stores are smiling also albeit after making changes to

meet customer demands. Stores like Ram Chandra Krishna Chandra (RCKC) replenish their stocks every week during the season and keep a close watch on international trends to mould Indian outfits. As Managing Director Amit Rastogi says, "Brides want contemporary shapes and silhouettes." Delhi's RCKC sells up to 7,000 outfits (costing anything between Rs 20,000 and Rs 50,000 on an average) every season as compared to a couturier who may sell between 80 and 100.

Traditional designs never go out of style either. A testament to this are the thriving south Indian sari stores, like Nalli. The demand for traditional saris has not declined, despite the popularity of big labels. Nalli now has 10 branches all over India and during the wedding season, the Mumbai branch alone sells over 300 wedding saris, each costing between Rs 15,000 and Rs 50,000. Not surprisingly, it was Aishwarya Rai Bachchan's wedding-wear choice as well. "The only change has been in customer demand, for new designs even in traditional Kanjeevarams," says M.A. Balamurugesan, vice-president, Nalli, Mumbai. For the designers, as well as for the traditional sari stores willing to go modern, it's all about milking the cash vows. ■